ExoSound & GaiaStage

Music Making towards Sustainable Socio-Material Arrangements

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Background and early findings of two related projects:

- ExoSound: Electronic musical interactions in outdoor places
- GaiaStage: Pedal powered performance stage, trialing sustainable, low carbon solutions for outdoor music events.
- Both: Technical interactions as situated, socio-material arrangements
- Both: Shifting focus from the materiality of technology to the social





Introduction: Inappropriate Traces

- Practices leave material traces in the Urbanoscene, anthropological traces become evident in the geological layer.
- Traces challenge the resources required for our subsistence, drastically reduced biodiversity
- From ethical point of view, our actions and practices are inappropriate
- Appropriation as *modus operandi* of everything technical, central to earlier work:
- Every action is an appropriation that is either appropriate or inappropriate,
- Appropriation as *Landnahme*, is a term discussed by Bruno Latour’s reading of Carl Schmitt’s Nomos
- According to Arendt, Schmitt's Landnahme is *de facto* annexation. According to Arendt's *Nomos* the negotiation of law happens *a priori* to appropriation.

Introduction: How to Land

Appropriation —Landnahme — "*Taking land*" — Landing —Atterrir

- question of *atterrir*, of how to land, is one of appropriate or inappropriate appropriation.
- In both projects, the idea of how to *engage with the world*, où atterrir, is a core motivation and aims to contribute to the differentiation between the possible ways of landing, how to engage with materiality, possibly following Arendt rather than Schmitt.

Bias on Materiality

- Music industry runs events largely as before, despite high carbon footprint
- Events get bigger, small venues continue to disappear
- Album sales are replaced by music streaming services, providing artists with a fraction of their previous income
- Pressure for musicians to play profitable large-scale events.
- emphasises the importance of competitive economic growth in policies (European Unions Green Deal,UNESCO’s agenda 2030
- Notion of innovation and technical novelty irreversibly linked to the making of new products, not *practices*.
- Digitalisation, and “AI” could constitute less material notion of technology: Algorithms as (social) practice
- ExoSound and GaiaStage propose alternatives: ExoSound developes outdoor practices rather than outdoor gadgets, GaiaStage emphasises interdependence of systems through Low.tech practices

Actor-Network

- Actor-network theory as level playing field for human and non-human actants, lends itself methodologically to our projects because human action is just one part of the socio-material arrangement.
- We do this in a radical way where we are interested as much in “Peter addressing the stone as to the stone addressing Peter” *(Latour 2005)*
- We mediate and negotiate our role as musickers = music actors amongst others.
- Musicking, *(Small 1999)*, generalises music making as broad activity that consists of more than solely singing or playing an instruments, but a relational practice:

> *“The act of musicking establishes in the place where it is happening a set of relationships, and it is in those relationships that the meaning of the act lies”.*

ExoSound I

- Mobile technologies paradigm shift
- ExoSound project contributes to the development of electronic sound practices in an off-grid, outdoor context,
- specific focus on relationality, environmental coupling, and participatory agency.
- Sessions of situated practice in an outdoor setting

ExoSound II (Methotology)

- Observe our experiences according to wildly variable factors of weather/social situations.
- Control some factors by returning to same place at several occasions, and limiting our technical set-up to repeatable default scenarios.
- Auto-ethnographical field notes and audiovisual documentation, reflective group discussions
- Research output of ExoSound is the development if its artistic practice, open source software and theoretical contributions to musicology

GaiaStage I

- Activist music research case study in Science and Technology Studies: Can sustainable low-tech practices propose a paradigm shift towards technologies that are more social than material?
- Based on Lucy Suchman’s definition of machines as socio-material arrangements (Suchman 2007), we explore if a shift from the material to the social can make technologies more sustainable.
- Enable sustainable technical practices that require less materials, by being more social
- Dissemination: Music Events; publications in digital humanities, sustainability science, STS and artistic research.

GaiaStage II

- Bruno Latour's reading of James Lovelock and Lynn Margulis' Gaia Theory: Living organisms interact with inorganic surroundings on Earth to form a complex system maintaining conditions for life on the planet.
- Latour's reading: Gaia is not stable system, but fragile balance
- GaiaStage thematises interdependences of systems in Gaia.
- Stage is not the boards it is built of but the performance it situates.
- overarching question about a change in the technological paradigm.
- Auto-ethnographic field notes and audio-visual documentation.

Closing Remarks

- Early findings: Reduction to portable, distributed equipment, possibilities of ad-hoc performances, and independence of the electrical grid, makes us engage with the situation, connect to the place, and encourages interactions.
- A stage is not the boards it is built of, but the performances it situates. The shift from a material engagement through technology to a social one, is a way of landing (atterrir) that promotes appropriate practices.
- Even if both projects have only just started, we see weak signals that a reconceptualisation of technology as socio-material arrangement has the potential to change the way we do things,
- Technologies are not deterministic givens we have to adapt to, but material practices we can choose or refuse to perform.
- A socially navigated materiality can reduce the adverse impact of technical actions by being more social than material.

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References

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